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Rarely have two rival champions differed in demeanour as starkly as the tempestuous Aryna Sabalenka and the poker-faced Elena Rybakina. The two burning questions for the US Open finalists were: How would Sabalenka handle her emotions? And would Rybakina show any at all?

Before the final, the two had fired explosive salvos at each other in 17 matches, with the 28-year-old Belarusian clinging to a 10-7 edge over the 27-year-old Russian-born and -trained Rybakina, now representing Kazakhstan. This season, the rivalry heated up to a boil with four matches, all on hard courts. Sabalenka prevailed at Indian Wells and Miami for the Sunshine Double in March.

But Rybakina ruled where it mattered most — the Majors. Down 3-0 in the deciding set, she rampaged to a stunning 6-4, 4-6, 6-4 victory in the Australian Open final for her second Grand Slam title, nearly four years after winning Wimbledon. Months later, she has won her third.

Entering this US Open, different women had won the last seven Majors, and the current top four — Sabalenka, Rybakina, Jessica Pegula and Coco Gauff — all had a chance to end up No. 1 when the tournament ended. That both finalists surmounted exceedingly tough draws reinforced their new Big Two status.

Defending champion Sabalenka steamrolled over three opponents to start her bid for a rare US Open three-peat, achieved only by Chris Evert (1975-78) and Serena Williams (2012-14) in the Open Era.

She faced her first challenge against the immensely gifted Taylor Townsend, who had three career wins over top-five players, including a stunning 7-5, 6-2 upset over Mirra Andrejeva here last year. Down a service break in the second set against Townsend, Sabalenka recovered for a 6-4, 6-3 win replete with brilliant shots.

In her blockbuster quarterfinal against Linda Noskova, Sabalenka's tie-break prowess trumped everything. She seized the first-set breaker 7-1. Noskova mixed up her shots and managed to absorb Sabalenka's relentless

power to take the second set 6-3. In the match tie-break, the Czech kept it close, belting a forehand winner to narrow Sabalenka's lead to 8-7. But the Belarusian Basher hit an unreturnable serve and a nifty second-serve slice ace to close out the 7-6(1), 3-6, 7-6(7) victory, in the best women's match of the tournament.

Sabalenka conquered Jessica Pegula in the 2024 US Open final and 2025 semis and faced her again in the penultimate round. Inspired by superstar striker Ronaldo in her player box, Sabalenka played super tennis. She pounded 29 winners (against 12 for Pegula) and grabbed 14 of 19 points on Pegula's weak second serve to overwhelm her otherwise solid but unspectacular foe 7-5, 6-2.

The bottom half of the draw abounded with intriguing matches, none better than 14th-seeded Iva Jovic's 7-5, 3-6, 7-5 thriller over 17th-seeded Alexandra Eala.

Like two evenly matched, highly skilled, intensely focused middleweight boxers, they traded blows, with Eala pulling ahead 4-2 with points for 5-2 in the deciding set. Jovic boldly attacked the Filipina lefty's vulnerable second serve, averaging only 76 mph, with blistering returns from five feet inside the baseline. The 18-year-old American wound up with 43 winners and only 27 errors.

Madison Keys' rollercoaster ride at Flushing Meadows took her to a super high when she escaped five match points in a 5-7, 6-4, 7-6 (5) comeback over Hungary's Anna Bondar. In the next round, Keys learned why tennis is sometimes called 'the cruelest game'. She plummeted to a super low against Zheng Qinwen, choking away a 5-0 third-set lead and a match point.

Zheng's resurgence also snared Iga Swiatek in a mild 7-5, 6-3 upset. The six-time Grand Slam champion, just 25, has surprisingly fallen from the elite after not advancing past the quarterfinals at the last five Majors.

The Polish speedster with a wicked forehand simply has no Plan B nor Plan C when her predictable, one-dimensional grinder game is off. She desperately needs the versatility that a reliable net game and finesse shots would provide.